



Cambridge (CIE) IGCSE English Language



Your notes

Section B: Composition

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Your notes

Descriptive Writing: What the Question is Asking

Descriptive Writing: What the Question is Asking

In Section B of Paper 2, you will be given the choice of four titles: Questions 2 and 3 will be descriptive writing titles, and Questions 4 and 5 will be narrative writing titles. Each of the options is worth 40 marks and you are only required to choose one of them (either descriptive **or** narrative). While descriptive writing will contain elements of narration, and vice versa, it is important to be aware that there is a distinction between the two styles of writing and you must shape your responses accordingly. You should therefore consider all four choices before selecting the one you feel will best allow you to demonstrate your skills as a writer.

The following guide will help you to understand what the descriptive writing question is asking.

Overview

There will be two descriptive writing titles or scenarios to choose from (Question 2 and Question 3). You are required to write about 350–450 words, which is approximately 2–3 sides of A4 in standard-sized handwriting, and you will have one hour in which to do this. You will be awarded up to 16 marks for content and structure, and up to 24 marks for style and accuracy. For descriptive writing, this means:

Content and structure (16 marks)	Style and accuracy (24 marks)
The writing contains many well-defined and developed ideas and images which create a convincing overall picture with varieties of focus	- The writing contains precise, well-chosen vocabulary and varied sentence structures chosen for effect - Language and tone are suitable for the context - Spelling, punctuation and grammar are almost always accurate

Remember, in descriptive writing, your aim is to enable the reader to picture what you are describing in your mind. You should spend 15 minutes choosing your task and planning your writing, and 45 minutes writing your response (including 5 minutes at the end to re-read and check your work).

Breaking down the question

You should carefully consider the two question choices and plan your route through your composition, including how it will end, before you start writing. Consider how you can be convincing and original in your use of detail, and choose your vocabulary and sentence structures carefully to create specific effects.

The examples below are a selection of past CIE descriptive writing tasks:



Your notes

Write a description with the title, 'The nest'
Describe the preparations you make for an important journey
Describe trying to sleep before an important day
Write a description with the title, 'The view from the other side'

The wording of each task makes it clear that you are writing a description, not a story



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Exam tips

- Make sure you are not overly reliant on narrative to structure your response:
 - This results in answers which have limited descriptive content
- Your description should be closely observed and focused in content:
 - Try to make use of more striking and original images, rather than relying on stereotypical ideas and images
- Ensure that all of the words you choose contribute to the overall atmosphere and effect you want to create
- Do not confuse tenses in a paragraph:
 - If you use a flashback, ensure you have written in the past tense
 - If you use present tense verbs for effect, then ensure you do this consistently
- Do not use dialogue in a descriptive writing piece:
 - Descriptive writing also does not provide background information or develop character interaction
 - When describing people, you should focus on their body language or movements
- Zoom in and out of the image you are creating as if you are behind a camera
- Include some movement to contrast and add interest

- Use sensory language to create a clear mood, but adjust the focus and perspective as your paragraphs develop:
 - Descriptive writing should include movement and sound, but the “narrator” should be a silent observer
- Vary your sentence and paragraph lengths to keep the style and tone dynamic
- It is effective to repeat ideas related to colour:
 - Consider picking out a key detail in order to do this, such as the colour of houses’ roofs
- Remember, this is not a story:
 - You do not need to provide a “happy ending”



Your notes



Your notes

Descriptive Writing: How to Get Full Marks

Descriptive Writing: How to Get Full Marks

Section B requires you to write for a specific purpose and in a specific form. It is important that you write in the correct format and use the conventions of this form, as the mark scheme states that you should adapt your tone, style and register for different forms, purposes and audiences.

This means:

- The **tone** (the sound of the narrator's "voice") is appropriate and convincing
- The **register** (your vocabulary and phrasing) is suitable for the purpose
- The **style** of the writing (the sentence structure and the overall structure of your writing) is dynamic and engaging

When planning your response, it is a good idea to keep the tone, style and register in mind, as well as the conventions of the form. As with any extended piece of writing, planning is vital. You should spend 10 minutes mind-mapping your ideas before you start writing. Here, we will consider how you can produce an effective piece of descriptive writing.

How to structure your descriptive writing

Descriptive writing is observational writing. This means that the narrator does not interact with their surroundings, or other characters. In fact, no characters are crafted. Descriptive writing is like imagining you are behind the lens of a camera, describing a "snap-shot" of a moment. However, this does not mean the scene you are describing is static; it is important to note the movements and action you "witness".

Below is a suggested step-by-step structure for a piece of descriptive writing, including the techniques to use during each of the six steps:

Stage	Details of descriptive writing structure	
Step 1	Panoramic	▪ Broadly describe the scene ▪ Introduce the time and atmosphere
Step 2	Zoom	▪ Focus your lens on one segment of the "image" ▪ Choose smaller, less obvious details
Step 3	Single line	▪ Emphasise the key feeling of your description in one line



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Step 4	Shift	- Focus your lens on another segment of the “image” - If you started in the foreground, then move to something in the background
Step 5	Shift	Now move your lens to a final segment of the “image”, or suggest something that is just “off camera”
Step 6	Panoramic	- Zoom out again to look at the scene from a new perspective - How has it changed? Time? Atmosphere? Mood?

Remember, you can include action or movement in your description, but this should not involve any story progression or interaction. Any action should only cover a short period of “real time”, such as the wind blowing a basket over. Something seemingly inconsequential could move in the background, which is especially effective if you contrast this with things that remain still.

Your paragraphs should be appropriately linked, but should vary in terms of size and structure. Variety and accuracy are key; you are bringing a scene to life for your reader, so they should be able to picture it, hear it, even smell it!



Examiner Tips and Tricks

Remember, this is an extended written response. Therefore, the most effective answers will demonstrate a well-planned answer which has considered what details are the most interesting to the reader and the most effective way to order the writing.

Descriptive writing techniques

Tone

Descriptive writing should craft a tone of voice in keeping with the mood of the scene. This means your sentences should reflect the atmosphere. For example, if the scene is mysterious and frightening, your sentences should reflect this suspenseful mood.

In order to craft a tone in keeping with the mood of your description, consider how you can use sentence lengths and types:

- Short sentences reflect tension and unease, e.g. “No sound could be heard.”
- Longer sentences and listing can create a sense of being overwhelmed, or of abundance, e.g. “The market was laden with apples, grapes, oranges, loaves of bread, chunks of cheese and every type of vegetable one could imagine.”



Your notes

Style and register

The style of your descriptive writing is closely related to the language you use. For example, the best descriptive writing responses show evidence of careful word choices and the deliberate but judicious use of linguistic techniques.

Descriptive writing helps the reader to visualise the person, place, or situation being described. Your word choice and linguistic techniques should conjure a vivid, sensory impression in the reader's mind.

The best way to do this is to:

- Use vocabulary which is useful to the reader:
 - For example, describing something as “brilliant” or “amazing” is not descriptive
 - Be specific and ambitious in your choice of adjectives
- Use sensory language to bring the scene to life:
 - Focus not just on what can be seen, but also what can be heard, smelled or felt
- Emphasise key ideas or impressions using language techniques and imagery:
 - For example, you could use a simile to create associations about size or colour
 - Personification is a useful technique when describing weather or objects
- Ensure you describe the important details:
 - For example, you do not need to describe every inch of a person or scene bit by bit; instead, focus on key features

When considering the detail you should include in your description, it is useful to consider the types of things that bring a scene to life. These things are normally rooted in **contrast**. For example:

Sound and silence	■ Noise contributes to the reality of a scene: ■ Chatter, background noise, the weather or nearby wildlife all bring the scene to life ■ Using moments of silence can also be effective: ■ A momentary lull, or a really purposeful moment of quiet
Movement and stillness	■ Some things may move: ■ This could be the main focus of your writing, or something in the background ■ It could be human, animal or object – use personification



Your notes

	▪ Powerful verbs and adverbs can create dynamic movement in a piece of writing ▪ For example: "The swarming, struggling crowd." ▪ Other things will remain still: ▪ Try to focus on things that resist being moved, or whose stillness is in contrast with the movement of something ▪ Avoid cliches such as "still as a statue"
Light and dark	▪ There will be sources of light, so describe them: ▪ But also describe the way the light hits other things in your description ▪ Where there's light, there's also darkness: ▪ Consider what shadows are cast or where the light does not reach ▪ Who, or what, is left in the darkness?



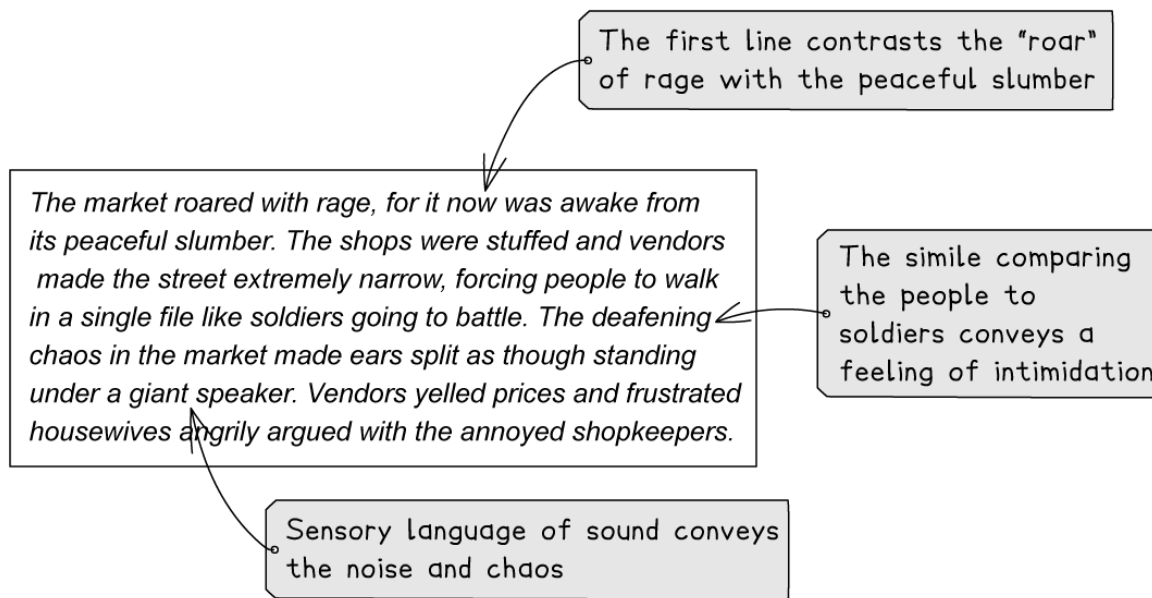
Examiner Tips and Tricks

Keep using sensory language throughout, but adjust the focus and perspective as your paragraphs develop. Make sure that you include description of movement and description of sound to effectively craft a mood.

Let's consider the following example of an opening paragraph of a piece of descriptive writing:



Your notes



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Steps to success

1. Read the two task options carefully:
 - Decide which one you can best picture in your mind
2. Spend 10 minutes planning your writing:
 - Use a mind-map or a table
 - Use the "panoramic, zoom, single line, shift, shift, panoramic" six-step structure
3. Write down some reminders of figurative language or literary techniques to include to add interest and detail:
 - It might be helpful to jot down "sound and silence", "movement and stillness" and "light and dark" to prompt you
4. Write your description, sticking to your plan
5. Try to leave five minutes at the end to re-read your writing carefully, correcting any obvious mistakes you have made



Your notes

Model Answer: Descriptive Writing

Model Answer: Descriptive Writing

In Section B of Paper 2, you will be given the choice of four titles: Questions 2 and 3 will be descriptive writing titles, and Questions 4 and 5 will be narrative writing titles. Each of the options is worth 40 marks and you are only required to choose one of them (either descriptive or narrative). While descriptive writing will contain elements of narration, and vice versa, it is important to be aware that there is a distinction between the two styles of writing and you must shape your responses accordingly. You should therefore consider all four choices before selecting the one you feel will best allow you to demonstrate your skills as a writer.

The following guide will provide you with a descriptive writing model answer, based on a past paper task.

Planning your descriptive writing

Once you have decided on your choice of title from the options, you should spend 10 minutes planning your writing.

Let's take this descriptive writing task as an example:

“Describe trying to sleep before an important day.”

We can use “panoramic, zoom, single line, shift, shift, panoramic” six-step structure to plan our response:

Stage	Suggested techniques and details	
Step 1	Panoramic	▪ Introduce motif of clock ▪ Dark outside, contrasting with light and stillness ▪ Describe what I can hear and feel
Step 2	Zoom	▪ Focus on a fly – add movement and sound
Step 3	Single line	▪ Turn over/re-adjust bedding
Step 4	Shift	▪ Focus on what is going on in my mind ▪ Use imagery to convey inner thoughts
Step 5	Shift	▪ Describe what can be heard outside in the street

Step 6	Panoramic	▪ Wake up – must have fallen asleep ▪ Describe changes in light and atmosphere ▪ Return to motif of clock – late
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Your notes

Descriptive writing model answer

The following model answer demonstrates a top-mark response to the above task:



Your notes

The first paragraph employs contrast and literary techniques to establish an eerie atmosphere in the middle of the night

The soft glow from the digital display flickered as the minutes sluggishly passed. The pale green cast an eerie shadow across my bed, while outside was as dark as a raven's pupil. The streetlight outside of the window had blown its bulb and towered, redundantly, over the pavement. Nothing moved, apart from me, anxiously turning and fidgeting my blankets into a tangle. I heard a faint hum from downstairs; the sound of the dishwasher automatically starting, churning and rumbling the plates from dinner until they sparkled. My mind churned like the machine, impossible to turn off now it had started. I checked the clock again. The night felt endless.

The second paragraph zooms in on a detail and incorporates movement

I shuffled over to turn on the light. Silhouetted against the inside of a shade, a fly lazily crept to the top, balancing on the rim like a tiny tightrope walker. I watched as it fluttered its wings slightly, before it took off in a frenzy of buzzing around the top of my bed, going nowhere in particular. I wondered what its purpose was. Why was it here? It hummed close to my face and I swatted it away gruffly. It landed back on the rim, satisfied with its little flurry of activity, as I reached over to turn off the light again.

I straightened out my blankets and turned again.

A single sentence is used for contrast and effect

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Your notes

The motif of the clock
is woven throughout
the response

The clock's mechanical glow informed me that only a few minutes had passed. I sighed and attempted to still my mind. I had numbers, facts and figures spiralling down a rabbit hole in my mind, becoming jumbled and muddled. I could see the dim outlines of my post-it notes, meticulously written and ordered, with all of the information I could ever need neatly written in my careful handwriting. But now all of that order had turned to chaos, as I struggled to remember even the simplest of equations. I needed to get some sleep, but my brain point-blank refused to let me.

Outside, I heard the sudden honking of a horn and a dog's incessant barking. Voices muffled by wall and curtain were just about audible, sounding like they were being spoken through a thick soup of fog. A car door slammed; the dog's barking became increasingly urgent. Voices raised again, before another slam and the roar of an engine increased and then faded out as the car disappeared down the street. The dog stopped barking and all was still once again. I stared at my curtains, considering whether to go downstairs to make myself a drink.

The focus shifts
to something
"off camera",
using sensory
language

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Your notes

The final paragraph indicates a shift in time and mood

The light now was different. The glow from the clock was less lurid, more muted, and the darkness of the room less extreme. I lazily looked up at my curtains once again, and my mind registered that the soft light of day had altered the atmosphere in the room from one of suspended animation to action. I turned over and saw the time. Like a jack-in-the-box, I jumped wildly out of bed. What was, just a few seconds ago, stillness and peace, was now urgency and panic. I was late.

It contrasts the stillness that had come before with a new, frenzied activity

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Unannotated model answer

The soft glow from the digital display flickered as the minutes sluggishly passed. The pale green cast an eerie shadow across my bed, while outside was as dark as a raven's pupil. The streetlight outside of the window had blown its bulb and towered, redundantly, over the pavement. Nothing moved, apart from me, anxiously turning and fidgeting my blankets into a tangle. I heard a faint hum from downstairs; the sound of the dishwasher automatically starting, churning and rumbling the plates from dinner until they sparkled. My mind churned like the machine, impossible to turn off now it had started. I checked the clock again. The night felt endless.

I shuffled over to turn on the light. Silhouetted against the inside of a shade, a fly lazily crept to the top, balancing on the rim like a tiny tightrope walker. I watched as it fluttered its wings slightly, before it took off in a frenzy of buzzing around the top of my bed, going nowhere in particular. I wondered what its purpose was. Why was it here? It hummed close to my face and I swatted it away gruffly. It landed back on the rim, satisfied with its little flurry of activity, as I reached over to turn off the light again.

I straightened out my blankets and turned again.

The clock's mechanical glow informed me that only a few minutes had passed. I sighed and attempted to still my mind. I had numbers, facts and figures spiralling down a rabbit hole in my mind, becoming jumbled and muddled. I could see the dim outlines of my post-it notes, meticulously written and ordered, with all of the information I could ever need neatly written in my careful handwriting. But now all of that order had turned to chaos, as I struggled to remember even the simplest of equations. I needed to get some sleep, but my brain point-blank refused to let me.

Outside, I heard the sudden honking of a horn and a dog's incessant barking. Voices muffled by wall and curtain were just about audible, sounding like they were being spoken through a thick soup of fog. A car

door slammed; the dog's barking became increasingly urgent. Voices raised again, before another slam and the roar of an engine increased and then faded out as the car disappeared down the street. The dog stopped barking and all was still once again. I stared at my curtains, considering whether to go downstairs to make myself a drink.

The light now was different. The glow from the clock was less lurid, more muted, and the darkness of the room less extreme. I lazily looked up at my curtains once again, and my mind registered that the soft light of day had altered the atmosphere in the room from one of suspended animation to action. I turned over and saw the time. Like a jack-in-the-box, I jumped wildly out of bed. What was, just a few seconds ago, stillness and peace, was now urgency and panic. I was late.



Your notes

Commentary

- The first paragraph employs contrast and literary techniques to establish an eerie atmosphere of the middle of the night
- The second paragraph zooms in on detail and incorporates movement
- A single sentence is used for contrast and effect
- The motif of the clock is woven throughout the response
- The focus shifts to something "off camera", using sensory language
- The final paragraph indicates a shift in time and mood
- It contrasts stillness with activity

Summary

- Remember, you are not writing a story, so think of describing a scene as though from behind the lens of a camera
- Spend 10 minutes planning your writing, using the suggested six-step structure above
- Allow five minutes to re-read and check your writing for any obvious mistakes with spelling, grammar or punctuation
- Employ sensory language, shifts in perspective, figurative language and contrasts to add interest and detail to your writing
- Do not include dialogue
- Vary your sentence and paragraph lengths
- Make sure you add movement to your description



Your notes

Narrative Writing: What the Question is Asking

Narrative Writing: What the Question is Asking

In Section B of Paper 2, you will be given the choice of four titles: Questions 2 and 3 will be descriptive writing titles, and Questions 4 and 5 will be narrative writing titles. Each of the options is worth 40 marks and you are only required to choose one of them (either descriptive **or** narrative). While descriptive writing will contain elements of narration, and vice versa, it is important to be aware that there is a distinction between the two styles of writing and you must shape your responses accordingly. You should therefore consider all four choices before selecting the one you feel will best allow you to demonstrate your skills as a writer.

The following guide will help you to understand what the narrative writing question is asking.

Overview

There will be two narrative writing titles or scenarios to choose from (Question 4 and Question 5). You are required to write about 350–450 words, which is approximately 2–3 sides of A4 in standard-sized handwriting, and you will have one hour in which to do this. You will be awarded up to 16 marks for content and structure, and up to 24 marks for style and accuracy. For narrative writing, this means:

Content and structure (16 marks)	Style and accuracy (24 marks)
The plot is well-defined and strongly developed with features of fiction writing such as description, characterisation, effective climax and convincing details	- The writing contains precise, well-chosen vocabulary and varied sentence structures chosen for effect - Language and tone are suitable for the context - Spelling, punctuation and grammar are almost always accurate

Remember, in narrative writing, your aim is to craft a convincing story. You should spend 15 minutes choosing your task and planning your writing, and 45 minutes writing your response (including 5 minutes at the end to re-read and check your work).

Breaking down the question

You should carefully consider the two question choices and plan your route through your composition, including how it will end, before you start writing. Consider how you can be convincing and original in your use of detail, and choose your vocabulary and sentence structures carefully to create specific effects.

The examples below are a selection of past CIE narrative writing tasks:

Write a story which involves an injustice
Write a story with the title, 'Cancelled'
Write a story with the title, 'The invitation'
Write a story which includes the words, '...nothing seemed to go right....'

The wording of each task makes it clear that you are writing a story

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Exam tips

- Ensure that your response is a well organised and thoughtful interpretation of whichever title you choose
- Demonstrate your ability to shape a narrative, including moments of tension and drama
- Use characterisation to create believable protagonists and characters
- Avoid cliches or over-used narratives, such as abandoned cabins in the woods
- Do not just “tell” a series of events:
 - Consider imaginative ways to tell your story, apart from just a chronological account
 - Include your characters' thoughts and feelings, not just what happens
- Do not over-complicate your language unnecessarily:
 - Do not underestimate the power of simple words and sentences to create powerful effects
- Start at your story's main setting, not in the journey or build up
- Ensure that all of the words you choose contribute to the overall atmosphere and effect you want to create
- Vary your sentence and paragraph lengths to keep the style and tone dynamic
- Do not over-use dialogue:

- Only use dialogue if it drives forward the plot and you are able to punctuate it correctly
- Consider the “message” of your story and how your characters represent this
- Consider the narrative perspective which will work most effectively for your story



Your notes



Your notes

Narrative Writing: How to Get Full Marks

Narrative Writing: How to Get Full Marks

Section B requires you to write for a specific purpose and in a specific form. It is important that you write in the correct format and use the conventions of this form, as to get the highest mark you will need to adapt your tone, style and register for different forms, purposes and audiences.

This means:

- The **tone** (the sound of the narrator's "voice") is appropriate and convincing
- The **register** (your vocabulary and phrasing) is suitable for the purpose
- The **style** of the writing (the sentence structure and the overall structure of your writing) is dynamic and engaging

When planning your response, it is a good idea to keep the tone, style and register in mind, as well as the conventions of the form. As with any extended piece of writing, planning is vital. You should spend 10 minutes mind-mapping your ideas before you start writing. Here, we will consider how you can produce an effective piece of narrative writing.

How to structure your narrative writing

Narrative story writing develops an idea to a conclusion. The way to achieve this in an exam is by planning an ending with a resolution (you should plan whether your story will end happily or not). In the exam, it is best not to plan a complex story which takes place over a long period of time, employs multiple characters or that has more than one setting or plot twist.

In order to adhere to the conventions of story writing, it is best to:

- Plan your writing in an order which takes your character (and reader) on a clear journey:
 - The best way to do this is to plan one main event
 - Ensure your plot is simple enough to be coherent and **cohesive**
- Consider employing structural techniques, such as a flashback:
 - This can give background information to the reader and provide context
 - Ensure you use past-tense verbs for this
- Develop your characters:
 - Consider essential narrative character archetypes, such as "villain", "victim", "hero", etc.
 - Decide on how your characters fit these descriptions

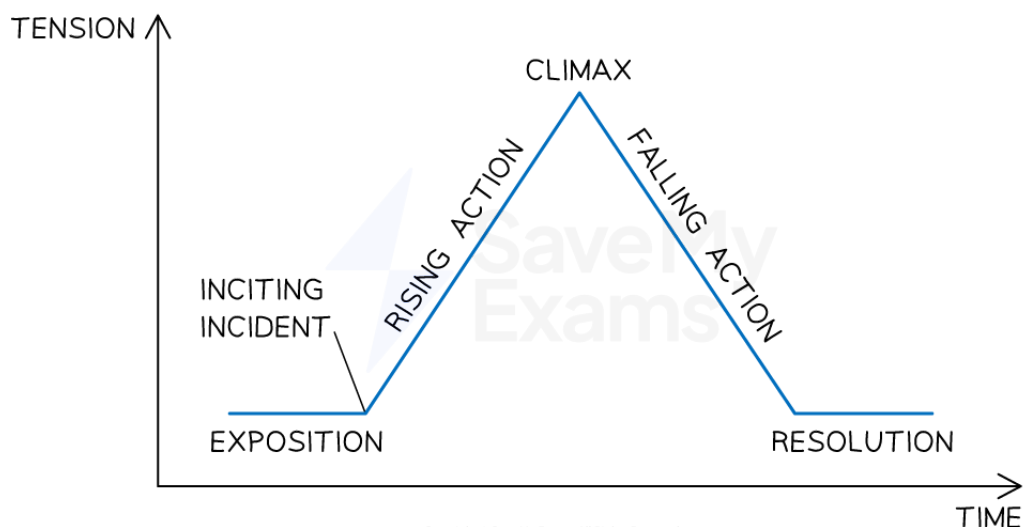


Your notes

- When describing people, focus on relevant details only:
 - For example, black and grey or green and blue
 - You could focus on their body language or movements
 - If using dialogue, the verbs you use to describe how your characters speak can reveal more about them than what they say, e.g. “shrieked”, “mumbled”, “whispered”
 - It is effective to repeat ideas related to colour
 - You can repeat ideas for emphasis:

Narrative writing responses should be structured into five or six paragraphs. You should plan your response carefully as you have limited time to create a cohesive plot. Writing a response which has not been planned is likely to have an abrupt ending, or no ending at all, which will not get you high marks.

There are lots of different narrative structures or arcs that you could use to plan your story. Bearing in mind you only have 15 minutes to plan, your story needs to be controlled and concise. One of the easiest ways to achieve this is to consider a five-part narrative structure, such as Freytag's Pyramid:



Stage	Description of narrative structure	
Step 1	Exposition (setting the scene)	Stick to one main setting and start at the location: ▪ Do not include a lengthy 'journey' before the main action of your story starts Hook your reader:



Your notes

		▪ Give them clues as to what will happen later, but do not give everything away all at once Decide which narrative perspective and tense you are going to write your story in: ▪ First person 'I' and the past tense are easier to control ▪ Stick to no more than two characters and introduce them Employ the five senses to create an atmosphere: ▪ The scene's mood should reflect your main character's mood This paragraph could end with an 'inciting incident', which prompts the rising action and moves the story forward
Step 2	Rising action	This paragraph should build tension, drama or interest: ▪ It should directly lead to the turning point of the story (the 'climax') This paragraph should also develop your character(s): ▪ You could use dialogue, monologue, direct or indirect characterisation to create well-rounded, 3D characters
Step 3	Climax	This is the turning point of your story: ▪ It is the moment everything changes and your character(s) cannot go back Your protagonist could face an external problem, or an internal choice or dilemma: ▪ Their choice is made in this paragraph You should vary your sentence structure, length and language here for dramatic effect



Your notes

Step 4	Falling action	What happens in this paragraph should be as a direct result of the climax paragraph: - It shows the consequences - It should also focus on your characters' thoughts and feelings as a result of the climax of the story - This further develops a sense of characterisation
Step 5	Resolution or denouement	You can choose to resolve your story, or end on a cliff-hanger: - However, a cliff-hanger is not a sudden ending; it is a suspenseful ending - It is also important to avoid cliches, such as 'I woke up and it was all a dream.' Your setting and atmosphere could reflect a change from the setting or atmosphere you established in your opening paragraph: - Or it could refer back to imagery you used in your opening paragraph to create a cyclical structure

Remember, each paragraph does not have to be the same length. In fact, better answers vary the lengths of their paragraphs for effect. What is important is to develop separate ideas or points in each paragraph, and to avoid repeating the same descriptions throughout your response.

Narrative writing techniques

Once you have planned out the structure of your narrative, it's a good idea to consider how to incorporate methods and techniques into your response. Below we have included some guides to help you when thinking about setting, characterisation and other linguistic techniques to make your narrative as engrossing as possible.

Setting

As this task assesses the ability to communicate clearly, effectively and imaginatively, it is important to consider how to use language constructively in a short story to convey an atmosphere or mood. Building an effective setting is key as it contributes to atmosphere and mood.

- Your setting should reflect your main character's mood:
 - You may know this as **pathetic fallacy**, which reflects the character's mood in the environment, e.g., "the lonely road"
- As your setting reflects your character's mood, your setting may change as the story progresses:



Your notes

- Contrasting scenes is an effective way to convey ideas and to engage your reader:
 - For example, your story may have started on a sunny afternoon, but may end as the sun sets or as a storm approaches
 - Whatever way you decide to contrast the scenes, ensure it reflects your character's mood
- The best answers build a clear setting before introducing other information, such as introducing character:
 - Describing setting is best done with **sensory language** as we experience places with all of our five senses
 - This means you could describe the dark, light, colours, sounds, smells and weather
 - The best way to clearly create setting is to allow an entire paragraph to describe the scene without confusing readers with other information like who is there
 - Ensure all of your descriptive language builds the same mood and avoid mixing ideas. For example: "The graveyard was dark, cold and smelled like fragrant flowers" is confusing for your reader
- However, do not give too much away all at once!
 - Keep your reader guessing and asking questions, such as "What is going on?", "Why is this like this?" and "Who is this?"
 - Think of establishing a setting a bit like the game "Taboo", in which you have to describe something without stating explicitly what it is

Characterisation

This question asks you to create a short story and therefore you will need to build some elements of detailed **characterisation**. This means you need to consider what your character(s) represent. They may represent an idea, such as hope or strength or abandonment, or you could include a villain to represent injustice or evil. It is best to limit yourself to two characters in the time you have.

Well-rounded characters are taken on a journey: a character should undergo some form of development or change. The mark scheme rewards answers which clearly and effectively convey ideas, meaning that you need to consider the most effective ways of building a character in a short piece of writing. Ideally, you should focus more on indirect characterisation than direct characterisation:

Direct characterisation	Indirect characterisation
▪ The writer describes the character through narration ▪ The writer describes the character's physical appearance, personality and the things that motivate them	▪ The writer hints to the reader what the character is like ▪ An impression is formed of the character through their speech, thoughts and feelings, interactions with other characters



Your notes

- | | |
|---|--|
| <ul style="list-style-type: none"> It is useful for giving broad details in a sentence or two, but if used too much direct characterisation will result in superficial characters that a reader is not able to relate to or engage with This is “telling” | <p>and what other characters say or think about them</p> <ul style="list-style-type: none"> It is useful for developing more complex, well-rounded characters that engage the reader This is “showing” |
|---|--|

Here, we will consider how to plan your character(s) effectively to engage your reader. This is what the examiner is looking for in your answer:

Characterisation	
Appearance (direct characterisation)	Your character’s appearance may not always be relevant: - It is worth considering if it is necessary to describe the colour of your characters’ hair, for example - Usually appearance is important if your character represents something, for example, a king, a soldier or someone in trouble - Facial expressions or descriptions can convey character effectively. For example, “her tear-stained face” or “he frowned” - If you choose to write in first-person, remember that it is rare that we describe our own appearance Third-person perspective can describe appearance more effectively
Movements and body language (indirect characterisation)	One of the most effective ways to describe a character is through their movements: - This is the way we judge people most accurately - Consider how you can describe your characters’ emotions or circumstances using movements, e.g., “His head dropped” - Verbs and adverbs can be used to effectively build characterisation - If you are including dialogue, think about alternative verbs to “said”, such as “whispered” or “bellowed”



Your notes

Monologue (indirect characterisation)	If you use the first-person perspective, a monologue helps readers engage with the character: ▪ This creates a personal tone and engagement with the character ▪ You can create a character's "voice" using punctuation, such as short sentences or questions: ▪ A short sentence indicates your character may be nervous, for example ▪ Using emotive language will help your reader understand your character better
Dialogue (direct and indirect characterisation)	Dialogue can convey the relationships between your characters and provide insights into what other characters think about each other: ▪ It is best to limit dialogue in your story, especially if you are not absolutely certain how to punctuate it correctly ▪ Use speech marks and punctuation accurately ▪ Carefully consider how the dialogue conveys an idea: ▪ Do not include dialogue which does not progress the characterisation or plot

Linguistic devices

When considering your choice of language and the techniques you wish to employ, you must always remember that you are making deliberate choices for effect. It is important to consider the **connotations** of words and phrases, and how these may add depth to your writing. For example, do your word choices evoke certain emotions or feelings in the reader, or do they reveal aspects of a character's personality, background or emotions? You should employ the principle of "show, not tell" in order to bring your writing to life in the reader's mind.

Below you will find a brief explanation of some of the key techniques you could employ in your narrative (or descriptive) writing:

Device or technique	Explanation	Example
Repetition	Repeating a word, phrase, image or idea. This is much more effective if you think of repetition as a	<i>Throughout life, I have learnt never to give up: never give up</i>



Your notes

	motif that you use throughout your piece of writing	<i>on my dreams; never give up on my hopes and never give up on myself.</i>
Alliteration	Remember, the words starting with the same consonant sound do not have to be consecutive. Consider the effect you are trying to achieve through the use of alliteration	<i>The swirling mist silently settled on the sleeping town.</i>
Metaphor	Metaphors can be as simple as figures of speech, but are especially effective where they are extended and developed	<i>She was the chief lioness among us, fierce, determined and strong. It was she who brought us all together.</i>
Personification	A great way to create atmosphere at the start of your writing is by personifying the setting to your story or description	<i>The weary old tree, its gnarled branches outstretched like weathered arms, whispered ancient wisdom to the breeze.</i>
Onomatopoeia	The representation of sound on paper should be more sophisticated than comic-book terms such as “boom”. It is also not helpful to put onomatopoeic words all in capital letters. Consider sound as a way of evoking the senses in order to create atmosphere	<i>The crackling fire whispered its secrets along with the gentle pop and sizzle of the logs as they surrendered to the flames.</i>
Simile	A simple comparison using “like” or “as” should be used sparingly, as this creates more impact	<i>Her smile was as radiant as the early morning sun on a summer’s day.</i>
Imagery	Engages the reader’s senses by using vivid and detailed language to create an image in the reader’s mind	<i>The sun-kissed waves crashed against the golden shore, their frothy white caps glistening in the morning light.</i>
Juxtaposition	Places two contrasting ideas, images or concepts side by side to highlight their differences or to create a striking effect	<i>The elegant ballroom was adorned with exquisite chandeliers and fine artwork, while the servants’ quarters below held nothing but bare walls.</i>



Your notes

Emotive language	Words or phrases that are intentionally used to evoke a strong emotional response in the reader	<i>The devastating aftermath left a trail of destruction, sorrow and misery.</i>
Power verbs	Verbs are doing, action or being words. Power verbs are the deliberate, interesting choice of verb to help the reader picture what you are writing. They can be especially useful for characterisation	<i>The man stooped, stumbling slowly towards the entrance.</i>
Pathetic fallacy	The ability to evoke a specific mood or feeling that reflects a character's internal or emotional state	<i>The lonely road beckoned him onwards with no end in sight.</i>

Steps to success

1. Read the two task options carefully:
 - Highlight which one you have a strong idea for
2. Spend five minutes planning your writing:
 - Use a mind-map or a representation of Freytag's Pyramid to plot out your story
 - Plan your characters - who they are, what they represent and how you will convey this
 - Decide on your narrative perspective - first or third person
3. Write down some reminders of figurative language or literary techniques to include to add interest and detail to your writing
4. Write your story, sticking to your plan
5. Try to leave five minutes at the end to re-read your writing carefully, correcting any obvious mistakes you have made



Your notes

Model Answer: Narrative Writing

Model Answer: Narrative Writing

In Section B of Paper 2, you will be given the choice of four titles: Questions 2 and 3 will be descriptive writing titles, and Questions 4 and 5 will be narrative writing titles. Each of the options is worth 40 marks and you are only required to choose one of them (either descriptive or narrative). While descriptive writing will contain elements of narration, and vice versa, it is important to be aware that there is a distinction between the two styles of writing and you should shape your responses accordingly. You should therefore consider all four choices before selecting the one you feel will best allow you to demonstrate your skills as a writer.

The following guide will provide you with a narrative writing model answer, based on a past paper task.

Planning your narrative writing

Once you have decided on your choice of title from the options, you should spend 10 minutes planning your writing.

Let's take this narrative writing task as an example:

“Write a story which involves an injustice”

We can use a five-part narrative structure to plan our response:

Step 1	Exposition/setting	- A house that nobody has lived in for a long time - Atmosphere is silent and uncared for
Step 2	Rising action	- Background information - grandparents' house - Light, laughter and joy - Narrator and sister playing in a treehouse
Step 3	Climax	- Accident involving the narrator's sister - Narrator gets the blame
Step 4	Falling action	- Aftermath - leave the house and return to the city - Family crumbles
Step 5	Resolution	Present day - narrator returns to the house



Your notes

Narrative writing model answer

The following model answer demonstrates a top-mark response to the above task:

The first paragraph uses personification to set the scene

The house had been the epitome of life and joy, and yet it was now dead. It was merely a shadow of its former glory, for the house was no longer alive, and never would be again.

Sunlight no longer danced through the windows and sounds of laughter were no longer heard; all that was left were the remains of a long since dead house. Cobwebs littered the wooden slats and broken walls. Dusty light-fittings stared down miserably at a table that would never again be laden with food and fun, and chairs that had not been warm for years stood redundantly, forgetful of their original purpose. As I stood in the hallway, the quiet crept through the empty rooms towards me, mocking me with its oppressive silence.

The story then shifts to the past, with ambitious word choices

The house was not always dead. I can wistfully recall all of my visits to this once beautiful place. Every summer holiday, my parents brought me to this house, where my grandparents lived, and their parents before them. Living in the city, I urged for this escape: my summers spent in nature were filled with joy and laughter. The bright sunshine, the gentle winds and the peace that had been introduced to me in this wonderful place were the things I now treasured. My sister and I would spend hours climbing the trees surrounding the house, building dens and having endless adventures, before returning, wild and weary, for our family meal and the analysis of the day. Our favourite spot was our treehouse, lovingly made by my grandfather and decked out by my grandmother with cushions, toys and books. There was a ladder for climbing up and a rope to swing down. My sister, not as confident at climbing as me, was only allowed to climb up and swing down under my supervision.

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Your notes

But one summer I had grown weary of supervising her. I wanted some time alone, to listen to music, mope about and generally be a teenager. My sister became a pest; a fly to be regularly swatted away with an irritated flick of my hand. I resented having to be the responsible older brother. That was why I was slouched on the sofa with my headphones on when my mother rushed past me, swiftly followed by my grandparents. The sun was still bright; the wind still gently grazed the trees, but now it was different. One moment, without supervision, and a slip of a foot meant that our favourite tree would never be scaled again.

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The climax of the story indicates a shift in tone, with indirect characterisation used to make it believable

Nature imagery is repeated throughout the story

In his grief, my grandfather cut the tree down, the treehouse collapsing into a pile of firewood at its base. My parents could not watch, nor could they bear to look at me. The blame was placed squarely on my shoulders. The injustice of it, mixed with my own guilt and grief, was too much for us all to bear. I was just fourteen. Hardly capable of being responsible for my own life, let alone someone else's. But that did not seem to matter.

It was twenty years before I returned. At first, I thought I had arrived at the wrong house. I could not match the ruin standing before me with the bright, happy place I had known. Flowers of all colours had filled the elegant front garden, but now there were just weeds. In that one simple house, birthdays had been celebrated, fireworks were launched and laughs were shared. Now, it was a mere shadow. It was no longer alive, and never would be again. And the blame and sense of unfairness - well, that will stay with me forever.

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The falling action describes the aftermath and the link to the story's title

The story finishes by returning to nature imagery and personification

Unannotated model answer



Your notes

The house had been the epitome of life and joy, and yet it was now dead. It was merely a shadow of its former glory, for the house was no longer alive, and never would be again.

Sunlight no longer danced through the windows and sounds of laughter were no longer heard; all that was left were the remains of a long since dead house. Cobwebs littered the wooden slats and broken walls. Dusty light-fittings stared down miserably at a table that would never again be laden with food and fun, and chairs that had not been warm for years stood redundantly, forgetful of their original purpose. As I stood in the hallway, the quiet crept through the empty rooms towards me, mocking me with its oppressive silence.

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But one summer I had grown weary of supervising her. I wanted some time alone, to listen to music, mope about and generally be a teenager. My sister became a pest; a fly to be regularly swatted away with an irritated flick of my hand. I resented having to be the responsible older brother. That was why I was slouched on the sofa with my headphones on when my mother rushed past me, swiftly followed by my grandparents. The sun was still bright; the wind still gently grazed the trees, but now it was different. One moment, without supervision, and a slip of a foot meant that our favourite tree would never be scaled again.

In his grief, my grandfather cut the tree down, the treehouse collapsing into a pile of firewood at its base. My parents could not watch, nor could they bear to look at me. The blame was placed squarely on my shoulders. The injustice of it, mixed with my own guilt and grief, was too much for us all to bear. I was just fourteen. Hardly capable of being responsible for my own life, let alone someone else's. But that did not seem to matter.

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Commentary

- The first paragraph uses personification to set the scene
- The story then shifts to the past, with ambitious word choices
- The climax of the story indicates a shift in tone, with indirect characterisation used to make it believable
- Nature imagery is repeated throughout the story
- The falling action describes the aftermath and links to the focus of the story's title: "injustice"
- The story finishes by returning to nature imagery and personification



Your notes

Summary

- Remember, plan the order and "flow" of your story
- Stick to one setting and no more than two main characters
- Vary your sentence and paragraph lengths
- Employ imagery and literary devices to bring your story to life
- Use indirect characterisation to make your characters realistic and believable
- Consider your story as a "scene" in a film:
 - It is not necessary to know everything about your characters
 - It is better to immerse the reader with vivid "showing" techniques, such as sensory imagery and interesting vocabulary
- Write with technical accuracy